This represents a stationary wave or standing wave, which means that this wave does not move either forward or backward, whereas progressive or travelling waves will move forward or backward. Further, the displacement of the particle in equation (11.63) can be written in more compact form,

$$y(x,t) = A' \cos(\omega t)$$

where, $A' = 2A\sin(kx)$, implying that the particular element of the string executes simple harmonic motion with amplitude equals to A'. The maximum of this amplitude occurs at positions for which

$$\sin(kx) = 1 \Rightarrow \text{kx} = \frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{3\pi}{2}, \frac{5\pi}{2}, \ldots = m\pi$$

where m takes half integer or half integral values. The position of maximum amplitude is known as *antinode*. Expressing wave number in terms of wavelength, we can represent the anti-nodal positions as

$$x_m = \left(\frac{2m+1}{2}\right)\frac{\lambda}{2}, \text{ where, } m = 0,1,2\ldots \quad (11.64)$$

For $m = 0$ we have maximum at

$$x_0 = \frac{\lambda}{4}$$

For $m = 1$ we have maximum at

$$x_1 = \frac{3\lambda}{4}$$

For $m = 2$ we have maximum at

$$x_2 = \frac{5\lambda}{4}$$

and so on.

The distance between two successive anti-nodes can be computed by

$$x_{\text{m}} - x_{\text{m-1}} = \left(\frac{2m+1}{2}\right)\frac{\lambda}{2} - \left(\frac{(2m+1)+1}{2}\right)\frac{\lambda}{2} = \frac{\lambda}{2}$$

Similarly, the minimum of the amplitude A' also occurs at some points in the space, and these points can be determined by setting

$$\sin(kx) = 0 \Rightarrow k\,x = 0,\pi,2\pi,3\pi,\ldots = \text{n}\,\pi$$

where n takes integer or integral values. Note that the elements at these points do not vibrate (not move), and the points are called *nodes*. The nth nodal positions is given by,

$$x_n = n\frac{\lambda}{2} \text{ where, n = 0,1,2,...} \quad (11.65)$$

For $n = 0$ we have minimum at

$$x_0 = 0$$

For $n = 1$ we have minimum at

$$x_1 = \frac{\lambda}{2}$$

For $n = 2$ we have maximum at

$$x_2 = \lambda$$

and so on.

The distance between any two successive nodes can be calculated as

$$x_{\text{n}} - x_{\text{n-1}} = n\frac{\lambda}{2} - (n-1)\frac{\lambda}{2} = \frac{\lambda}{2}.$$

EXAMPLE 11.20

Compute the distance between anti-node and neighbouring node.

Solution

For n^{th} mode, the distance between anti-node and neighbouring node is

$$\Delta x_{\text{n}} = \left(\frac{2n+1}{2}\right)\frac{\lambda}{2} - n\frac{\lambda}{2} = \frac{\lambda}{4}$$

11.8.2 Characteristics of stationary waves

(1) Stationary waves are characterised by the confinement of a wave disturbance between two rigid boundaries. This means, the wave does not move forward or backward in a medium (does not advance), it remains steady at its place. Therefore, they are called "stationary waves or standing waves".

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